

## Animal rights



Hobbes's materialist view of man as machine was to have much later implications in the field of computers and artificial intelligence, but also raised questions about the minds of other living things. Descartes believed that only humans had conscious minds, and regarded animals as automata (see [Animals as automata](#)). But if Hobbes was right, and despite being mere machines, we are still capable of reasoning and consciousness, perhaps the same is true of animals (unless they are 'zombies' – see [Other people's minds and consciousness](#)). The argument for animals having similar minds to our own became even stronger with Darwin's theory of evolution in the

19th century and its implication that humans are simply another species of animal. If animals have similar 'minds' to humans, then perhaps they can feel pain, fear and all the other things that we do. Accepting this raises moral, and even political questions: should our actions towards animals be as morally correct as they are towards other humans? Is it right for us to restrict their liberty, or worse, take their lives? In short, should animals have the same rights as humans?